

Homo Reciprocans

vol. 1



“The premises from which we begin are not arbitrary ones, not dogmas, but real premises from which abstraction can only be made in the imagination. They are the real individuals, their activity and the material conditions under which they live, both those which they find already existing and those produced by their activity.”

— Karl Marx, *The German Ideology* (Part I: Feuerbach)

Front & back cover artwork
Auguste Rodin, The Cathedral, 1908



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A handwritten signature in cursive script, appearing to read 'Shambhavi'.

—Editorial Note—

We would like to think that what we do is ours.

That our choices begin with us.

It's a clean story. Convenient.

However if this were true, nothing would have to be accounted for. Not where a decision came from, not what made it likely, not what made it necessary. A choice appears, and with it comes this sense that, something has started, as if action begins the moment it becomes visible. As if nothing precedes it.

This is where economic thought has learned to look for the most part, but behaviour rarely settles into that kind of clarity.

It is the weakness of economics which makes it work.

There has always been an awareness of this. As David Hume rhetorically asked “*who sees not that vengeance, from the force alone of passion, may be so eagerly pursued as to make us knowingly neglect every consideration of ease, interest, or safety?*”, we try to solve this puzzle in this publication and argue that what appears as irrational is very well within the frame, not outside it.

Across these pieces, we move to moments before the market, as we now know it, emerged. Where exchange does not come from agreements between equals but rather from relations which are structured through obligation, access, and power. What appears to us as participation, reveals itself as something which was already mediated and diffused, and then further sustained through systems that no longer need to announce themselves. Within the household, reciprocity holds through expectations instead of balance, and those expectations are internalised, repeated and rarely recognised. Then we look at economies that sit at the margins, where belonging becomes necessary for survival and refusal carries high cost. Even here exchange continues, but under conditions which violate voluntariness. In the present, as transactions are increasingly replacing continuity, what remains of exchange is its reorganisation into forms that no longer sustain what they depend on.

Finally, we extend our gratitude to those who contributed, and to what made that contribution possible. What appears here

is only a surface, what sustains it continues somewhere else. If there is anything to take away from this issue, it is perhaps this: what we recognise as choice is rarely where things begin and instead, is merely a point where they become visible.

*Print and Publications
Committee of EPSOC*

On Life Itself

There is this peculiar comfort in believing that life, at its most difficult, reduces itself to a decision. This thought makes it more digestible, palpable, because knowing that at some point, everything becomes clear enough to be evaluated, compared, and resolved, almost as if trying to attain some objectivity with decisions, usually because we don't always trust our emotions or have faith in ourselves.

It is this idea that appears across economic reasoning as well, that individuals, given enough information, will choose.

But what exactly is being assumed when life is reduced to a decision?

Economic reasoning begins with a very convenient fiction, that individuals exist as this self-contained agents, capable of evaluating alternatives, assigning utilities, and making choices. In its most extreme articulation,

this reduces existence itself to a binary thing, whether to continue or to stop, whether to have a cup of coffee or to die. This is almost impressive, if it weren't so false.

The appeal of this formulation lies in its clarity.

The problem lies in its falsity and over simplification, the flatness that almost absolves us.

The individual this model depends on does not exist.

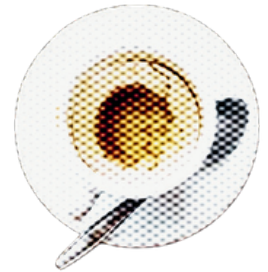
As Karl Polanyi argues in *The Great Transformation*, the idea that economic life originates in isolated individuals engaging in exchange, is in fact historically unfounded. Economic systems, for most of the human history, were organised through reciprocity, redistribution, and householding and not through markets, and certainly not through self maximising individuals. Exchange did exist, but it did not give rise to markets, nor did it produce individualism. .

As Polanyi makes it clear, the economy was always embedded within social relations, not separate from

them. This distinction is not minor. It is profound. Because once the individual is no longer taken as the starting point, the entire logic of decision making slowly starts to collapse. The question, then, is why the situation appears as an individual decision at all to begin with?

Let's take suffering as an example. It is often treated as private, internal, and idiosyncratic, as if it's something that belongs to a single person at a specific moment.

I'd like to challenge this framing because it fails when confronted with reality. Suicide rates do not distribute randomly. They tend to cluster across regions, increase during economic downturns, and sometimes even concentrate within particular demographic groups.



John Heartfield, 1967

These cannot be isolated events. They are patterned. There is a reason why these patterns exist. Suffering, like economic behaviour, does follow a pattern, and yet we keep trying to force it back into the language of the individual. This insistence is not neutral because it allows us to look away from everything that produces it.

The other day when I was strolling at silver beach, I came across two women who I ended up talking to. One of them told me about how she entered sex work at the age of twelve. Not because she preferred it, but because her mother fell ill, and access to hospitals was denied, partly due to lack of money and the fact that they belong to a lower caste community.

Here, the conditions came first. The “choice” arrived later, almost as if it were an afterthought we impose to make sense of it.

The other woman told me about how she had left a marriage while ago, consequently being cut off by her family because of it, and then recently being accepted again once she began earning. She is still the same person, but her ‘value’ in her family’s view changed.

The act does not change. What changes is how it is read within a set of relations, when it becomes tolerable, when it becomes respectable.

To describe either of these as utility-maximising decisions is insufficient. It is a distortion that hides more than it explains.

As Amartya Sen mentions in his critique of “rational fools,” human action cannot collapse neatly into self-interest or stable preferences. Commitments, identities, and social contexts, they do intervene. But even this logic does not go far enough because the problem is not just that individuals fail to behave like perfect decision-makers, it is that the very conditions under which decisions take shape are not individual at all to begin with.

The market does not stand apart from social life.

It is constituted through it...

...and this becomes obvious the moment you stop treating preferences as something which is fixed. They shift. Needs intensify and disappear. Objects do not carry value solely on their own, they also acquire it through the relations we attach to them ourselves. What feels indispensable at one moment becomes irrelevant the next, without any clear calculation guiding that shift. Another aspect to point out here is that, with time, this instability doesn’t get resolved. It changes form. What begins as acute suffering settles into numbness. What once seemed unbearable becomes routine. There is no stable horizon against which future utility can be calculated. Under such conditions, the idea of a coherent, forward-looking decision begins to fall apart.

There is also this parallel claim, that contemporary systems have already absorbed all such relational structures, that economic life has become autonomous, and that nothing remains outside it. This, however, does not hold true in practice because if it were to be true, there wouldn’t be such heavy dependence on several elements such as informal labour, care, trust, and constant negotiation just to sustain the current system.

The individual, therefore, is not a natural starting point, but instead a constructed abstraction, which becomes plausible only when the social conditions that produce it are obscured. To begin with this abstraction, and to build models upon it, is to misidentify the object of analysis from the outset.

So the question remains:

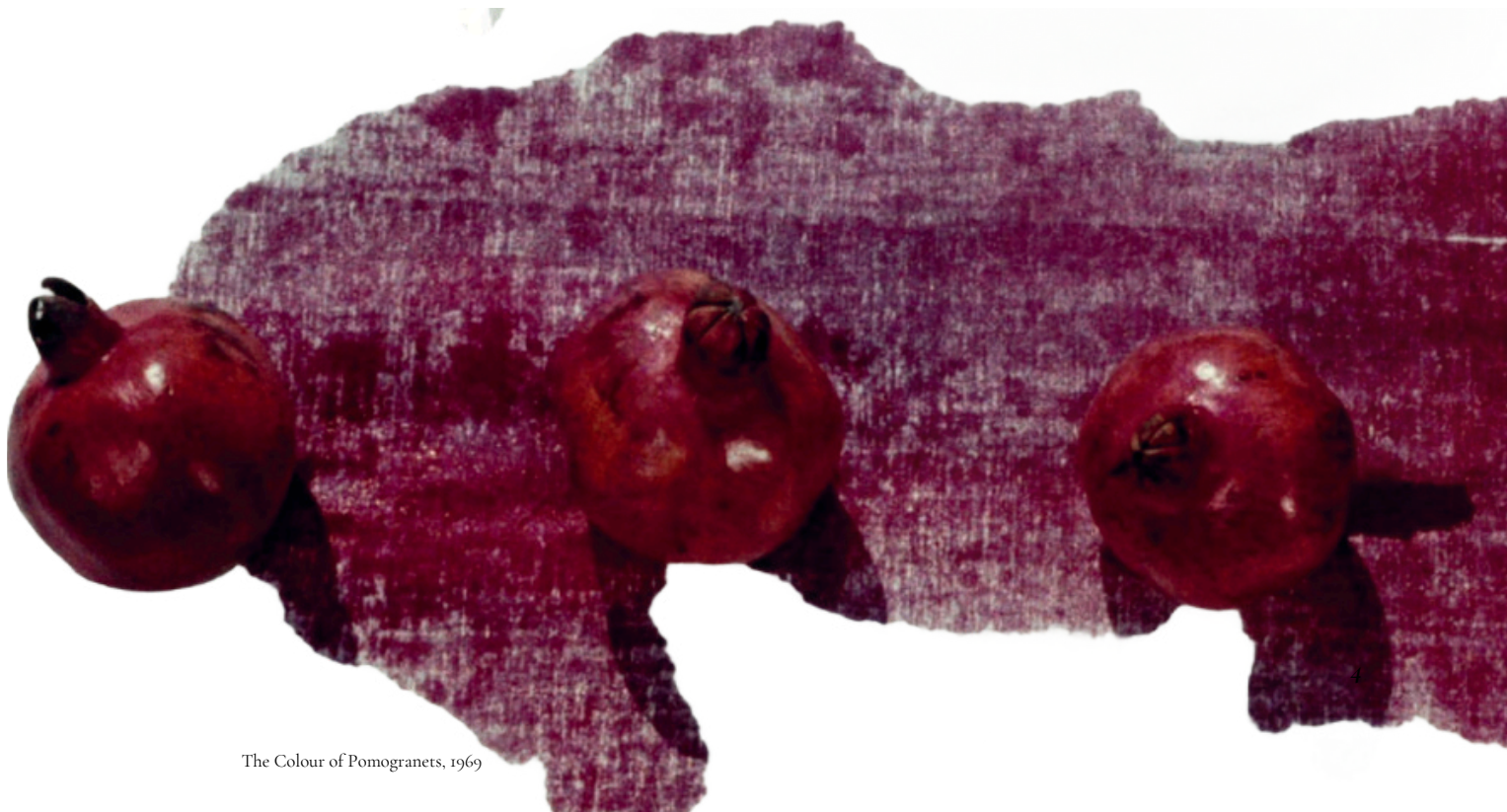
what exactly is being modelled when life is reduced to a decision?

If the answer excludes the networks within which individuals exist, the institutional arrangements that shape their possibilities, and the relationships that sustain or constrain them, then what is being modelled is not life, but rather a simplified projection of it.

By the time a decision appears as a binary, most of what determines it has already taken place elsewhere.

This confidence with which we assume that life can be calculated is not accidental. It is built on the belief that we understand what we are doing, that we are acting, choosing, deciding, but that confidence rests on a misrecognition, of where decisions come from and of what holds them in place.

What appears to us as a moment of decision, is merely a moment of visibility, of something which was already in motion.



The Colour of Pomogranets, 1969

Before The Markets

Economic exchange is often imagined to begin with a rather simple scene: **two individuals, each possessing something the other wants, arriving at an agreement through negotiation**. From this, it is assumed, markets emerge naturally due scarcity and human needs.

However, history suggests a very different starting point: one in which **exchange** was embedded within social structures and organised through **power, obligation, and control**.

In Central Australian communities such as the Dieri, the acquisition of goods like red ochre, which is used for ceremonial and symbolic purposes, required long-distance expeditions to regions where it was naturally available. Infact, it was such long-distance trade, or rather external trade, which came to being first, and then further gave rise to internal trade.



Anyway coming back to long distance trade, these were not just mere instances of casual barter between individuals. The Dieri used to primarily target this famous site, Parachilna (Bookatoo) in the Flinders Ranges to access this red pigment. This site was owed by The Adnyamathanha (means 'rock people' literally). Obtaining this pigment required navigating relationships which were structured by authority and power. Which is why for these expeditions, an armed group of 70 to 80 men were sent who were also required to perform certain rituals to get the permission to trade. These expeditions were collective and often risky, involving not only negotiation but the possibility of refusal, confrontation, or enforcement of unequal terms.

In such contexts, what appears as “exchange” cannot be understood as a voluntary agreement between equals. The trade of goods depended on who had territorial control, collective strength, and established hierarchies between groups. Access itself became the central variable which granted, restricted, or contested, rather than price. What moved was not only red ochre, but permission, recognition, and the ability to participate at all. Exchange existed, but it was inseparable from the structures that governed it.



A different but equally structured form of exchange can be observed in the Kula ring of the Trobriand Islands. In this system, shell necklaces (soulava) and armbands (mwali) was traded across a network of islands in fixed directional patterns.



These objects were not accumulated or consumed in the conventional sense, because their movement itself carried value, which was deciphered through their history, their prior holders, and the position of those who possessed them.

Participation in this system was not freely open. It required entry into a network of recognised partners, often maintained over long periods. Giving here was not a discretionary act in the everyday sense, it created a binding expectation of return. That was exchange.

To receive an object was to accept an obligation of returning something, which could not be refused without facing consequences. Failure to reciprocate risked loss of reputation, or exclusion from future exchanges, and a weakening of the relationships that sustained one's position within the network.

This is a form of exchange which is governed by continuity and is not driven by the incentive of immediate gains. Objects circulate, for maintaining the relationship itself. Value lies in participation and recognition, as much as the intrinsic value of the object being exchanged. The system regulates behaviour through expectation, status, and the possibility of exclusion.

There is a pattern in such instances. Exchange exists, but it is not organised through markets. It is embedded within social arrangements by the ways of territory, hierarchy, kinship, and obligation. Production and distribution are not separate economic processes, they are regulated through norms, authority, and collective structures that define who can access what, and under what conditions. Also the mere fact, that a tribe which used money differentiated it very little economically from other tribes on the same cultural level, who did not, shows how markets and their regulation through prices is constructed and is definitely not a natural extension of human exchange, which is embedded in social relations and reciprocity.



If early systems of trade and exchange were structured through power, obligation, and embedded relationships, then the figure of the independent individual engaging in voluntary trade cannot be taken as the starting point. It is a much later development, which requires the separation of economic activity from social context.

Exchange does not create relationships, it is created by them.

Exchange was reorganised into something that could be governed by markets.



The Native tribes of South-East Australia,
Alfred William Howitt, 1904

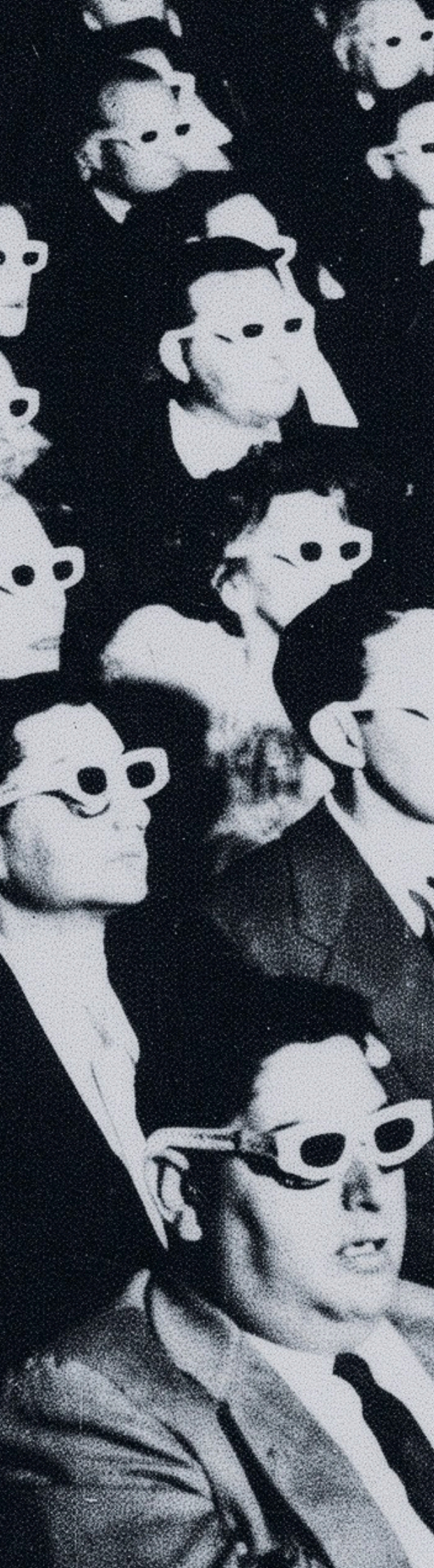
Must Have Been The Wind

I'm currently sitting in a circle of twelve, a man around forty-five years of age is giving some “क्वचन” hear him speak don't understand a thing he says. He's talking about Prana Vayu, shakti alignment, third eye- suddenly a Vedic story that traces back to 5000 years ago, where an incarnation of a Lord whose name... well I forgot saved someone in a disguise and that became a symbol of something I can't decipher. Did he personally eyewitness this? When his voice becomes a background noise I open one eye to cross-check if I am in the same realm or achieved some “मो” at last, all the apparent students have their one eye open, they too are scanning the room, the surroundings, everyone closes their eye shut when caught by each other, no body looked at guru ji, the background enlightening phrases are still there, but nobody thought of looking and the man leading the session.

Someone told me to touch some grass rather than spreading “rumours” through my voice and what's the better way to do this if not balancing my chakras? I found it doom scrolling. Facebook, since it's the only source of information that is most easily accessible and most interestingly displayed. This is my story and I am guessing everyone's around twelve identical people with identical vague emptiness, who found the identical solution on the identical platform, who showed up to the identical circle. The session ends. The incense smoke drifted somewhere. Curtains moved. Must have been the wind. I reached home, picked up someone's call and they asked me, “what did you gain in the session?” The first thing that came in my mind was I paid ₹11,111 and perhaps the last thing as well.

There is “The consumer”, it's a bright Sunday morning, sort of those where you plan a picnic, with waffles and all the stuff that feels warm to stomach and setting. They are in their study, picked up the phone and captioned, commented, threaded et cetera. They are explaining how markets trap us, how it's all decided by the hierarchy out there, how democracy corrupts us, how all of this is eating us alive, how we don't question enough, how politicians have failed us, how the boundaries that nations have is all a social construct, how education which is supposed to bring reforms is controlled by those in power- students learn what they want them to learn, how X happened five years ago and is contributing to Y which will ultimately result in Z in near future, how orientalism whatever that means contributes in construction of materialism and how minimalism is not a symbol of simplicity rather the display of wealth you accumulated in the time being, how industrialisation lead to this, how capitalism laidroots for all of this, how they killed wise men like Socrates, so on and so forth....The consumer has read the books they know.





They post it. The post travels. Reaches someone at 2am who shares it without finishing it. How it spread, must have been the wind.

The platform gives them a notification lined up with dozens more. Likes coming in. People commenting "so true" "this is eye opening" "you get it.", re-posting it, sharing it with the ones they feel will resonate, they spread the feeling of satisfaction.

Someone commented "The best books... are those that tell you what you know already." They gained something.

The system doesn't leave the consumers who see it. It already has a product for them too.

The wind: "Twas not I"

Against Choice



Agency Is Not Freely Chosen

What even is agency? To be able to freely choose, without external influence, to act on that choice—that is what we call freedom.

It sounds straightforward (almost embarrassingly obvious, the kind of thing that shouldn't require theory or centuries of struggle to establish).

And yet, the version of this “choosing individual” that economics begins with is already suspiciously clean: independent, rational, self-contained, with no history, no dependence, and no conditioning, just preferences, already formed, already stable, waiting to be expressed (which is convenient, because then you never have to ask where they came from).

Because if you did, the entire thing would start to unravel. As points out, this “separative self” is not an observation of reality but an assumption built into the model.

Real individuals are produced through social context. Preferences don't arrive already formed, they tend to take shape within structures that reward some behaviours and punish others, with a bias. So when we say women “choose,” what exactly are we referring to? a preference that exists independently, or one formed within structures that reward some behaviours and penalises others? if it is the latter (and it is) then calling this a “choice” hides the very conditions that made the outcome predictable in the first place.



Power Is Disguised as Normal Life

This is where the fiction of the rational, self-contained individual stops being just incomplete and turns into something actively misleading. It treats people as if they act freely, as if choices emerge in isolation, untouched by the conditions that produce them, but those conditions don't sit in the background, they structure the whole environment. Power does not always look like prohibition. It does not always say “no.” It does more, it arranges the world so that certain paths feel obvious, inevitable, even natural. It seeps deep into routine, into habit, into what begins to feel like ‘preference’. By the time something is experienced as a ‘choice’, much of the decision has already been made. What gets called “rational behaviour” is just adaptation, its just a response to constraints that no longer appear as constraints at all.

Power sustains itself by shaping what can be imagined, desired, and done. It often doesn't outright limit action but subtly seeps into crevices we forget, till you randomly experience a moment where you know something has shifted and the power which you should have on yourself is gone, it is that disgusting feeling, which you cant properly put into words, but you just know it. That is what your agency being violated feels like, and you just become a ‘woman’, and obviously it is normal.



The Economy Runs on Unpaid Women's Labour

They say it is care. They say it is natural, that it comes from within, that it is love. Which is interesting, because anything that is “natural” somehow ends up being required, repeated, and relied upon daily.

Cooking is not work, cleaning is not work, maintaining a household is not work (but remove it, and everything else stops). So what exactly is being described here? Not the absence of labour, but the absence of recognition.

Homo Economicus only recognises labour when it is waged, measurable, exchanged; everything else is treated as outside the economy, as if it sustains itself (which it does not).

As Silvia Federici argues, this invisibility is not accidental, housework had to be transformed into something “natural” precisely so that it would not be seen as work, because once it is seen as work, it becomes contestable. So instead, it is called love (which is doing a lot of work, for something that is supposedly not work).

The economy runs on labour it refuses to name, and the model built to describe that economy cannot see it.



Caliban and The Witch,
Silvia Federici, 2004



Reciprocity Breaks Here First

Economic theory assumes exchange, that something is given, something is returned, individuals participate voluntarily, each maximising their own utility. This assumes the possibility of refusal, and where refusal carries cost, be it social, economic, relational, then participation is no longer voluntary, it is structured. Within the family, this becomes even more pronounced. The household is often treated as a unit with shared interests, a space of cooperation rather than conflict, but as shows, this assumption collapses once we recognise that individuals within households do not have equal access to resources, and therefore not equal bargaining power.

So what appears as harmony is often the absence of visible conflict, not the absence of inequality, and what appears as reciprocity is often sustained expectation (which is not the same thing). The model calls it exchange; the structure enforces it as obligation.



Equality Cannot Be Deferred

The claim that gender can be addressed “later” is very weak. It assumes that economic participation unfolds on neutral ground, which means that once access is granted, inequality will simply reduce. This can be true only if the labour that sustains everyday life is already visible, already counted, already valued. It isn’t.

Entry into paid work does not replace unpaid labour, it just accumulates alongside it. What is framed as inclusion often reorganises inequality rather than solving it.

**The burden does not disappear,
it shifts,
it stretches,**

it intensifies.

A framework that cannot register this does not just overlook inequality, it goes the extra mile to reproduce it.

What it fails to see, it cannot challenge.
What it cannot challenge, it leaves intact.

So the promise of “later” is not neutral. It is a way of postponing recognition, and in doing so, ensuring that the structure remains exactly as it is.

The Gleaners,
Jean-François Millet, 1857



Economies That Should

Not Exist

Sushmit Deb

There are economies that appear to function like markets, but do not actually fully meet the conditions that make markets meaningful. Money circulates, transactions occur, roles are defined and yet, the structure beneath them is shaped by constraint. There is barely any choice. Money corrupts everything.

One of the clearest examples of this can be seen in Kamathipura in Mumbai, which is historically one of Asia's largest red-light districts, shaped by colonial urban planning, migration, and labour displacement. Over time, it has developed into this dense economic zone centred around sex work, which is deeply embedded in the city's functioning.

From a distance, it can be described in familiar economic terms a supply, demand and pricing, contribution to local economies.

But that description does not hold for long.

Entry into this system is not a simple decision. It comes into existence due to the absence of viable alternatives, and fueled by factors such as limited access to education, debt, migration, trafficking networks, and social exclusion. These are not external factors which are outside the market. They are the conditions that produce participation.

What looks like "labour supply" is the result of the accumulation of these constraints.

Within Kamathipura, work is organised through layered systems of dependence. Brothels, intermediaries, and informal protection networks regulate access to clients, housing, and income. Earnings move across these layers. Participation becomes possible while exit becomes difficult.

Transactions exist, but not independently. They are sustained by relationships that both enable and constrain at the same time.

Describing this as voluntary exchange between individuals captures only the surface. It leaves the structure that produces the exchange invisible.





A similar tension appears in the hijra economy with a different structure.

Here, economic activity is organised through culturally specific forms of exchange, mostly ritual performances, blessings, and public presence in return for payment. These interactions can be seen as a niche market, where a socially recognised role generates demand and sustains livelihood.

However, participation is not structured around isolated individuals responding to incentives. The guru-chela system establishes a framework of entry, training, and obligation.

Individuals get incorporated into this hierarchy that provides identity, protection, and livelihood when formal inclusion is absent elsewhere. Income is often shared, authority is centralised, and belonging becomes central to economic survival.

A variation of this structure can be observed in khusra communities in Pakistan, where individuals are recognised as intersex and seen as a 'deformity'.

This recognition alters the terms of visibility negatively and does not translate into full economic inclusion. So it doesn't help.

Consequently, livelihood continues to be organised through community-based systems similar to the guru-chela structure, where belonging, authority, and income remain interdependent.

The presence of recognition does not eliminate reliance on relational systems, it coexists with it.

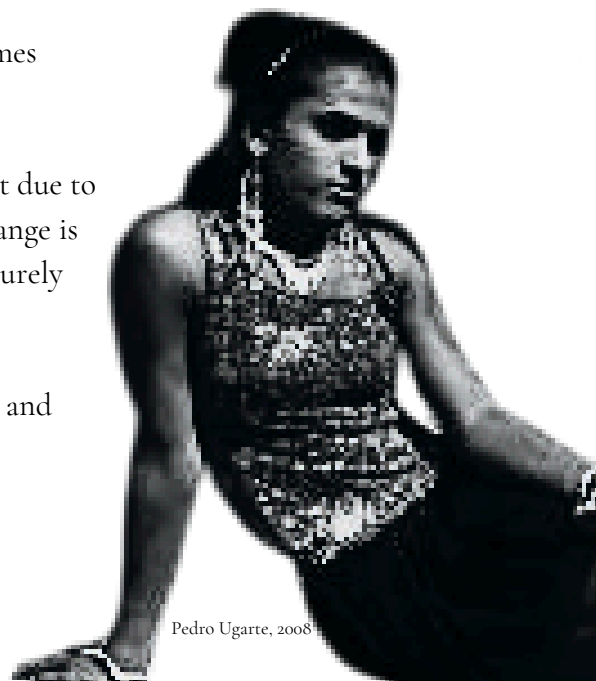
All these cases show that economic activity is embedded within relationships that shape participation. In the brothel economy, networks organise access, protection, and continuity. In the hijra and khusra economies, hierarchy and belonging structure entry and livelihood.

This changes how exchange is understood. In conventional economic theory, exchange is assumed to be voluntary and mutually beneficial, which occurs between independent individuals.

However, where the ability to refuse is limited, participation becomes structured rather than fully voluntary.

In Kamathipura, transactions occur within asymmetries which exist due to necessity and dependence. In the hijra and khusra economies, exchange is mediated by cultural legitimacy and social obligation rather than purely individual negotiation.

What appears as a price is inseparable from recognition, hierarchy, and constraint.



Pedro Ugarte, 2008



Reciprocity does exist in all these systems, but it does not operate under conditions of equality. In the brothel, relationships do provide support and protection while also reinforcing dependence and limiting exit.

In the hijra and khusra communities, the structures that sustain livelihood also maintain hierarchy and obligation. What is exchanged is security, identity, and continuity.

These forms of organisation challenge the assumptions of Homo Economicus, which centres on independent individuals making rational choices under neutral conditions.

Here, individuals are embedded within structures that shape both their options and their participation. Preferences are not expressed, not even once, they are outright formed within contexts of exclusion, adaptation, and constraint. The model can describe transactions, but it struggles to account for the conditions that turns those transactions into necessity.

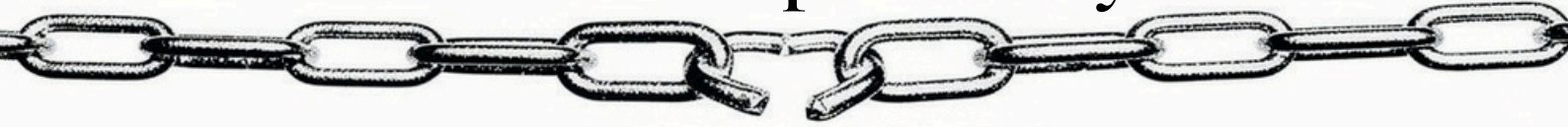
At the same time, these systems cannot be reduced to just exploitation alone, nor can they be romanticised as alternatives. They function as mechanisms of survival where formal economic structures fail to provide inclusion. They sustain life, even as they reproduce constraints.

Such marketization of needs and constraints demonstrate that economic activity can be organised through relationships rather than anonymous exchange, and that participation can be structured by necessity rather than choice. They show that markets, as described by standard economic models, are not always the primary or sufficient framework for understanding how people sustain themselves. These economies do not contradict economic theory, they simply expose its limits. They reveal the boundaries of a model that assumes independence, neutrality, and voluntary exchange by presenting forms of economic life where these conditions do not fully hold.

Reciprocity coexists with inequality.

The transaction is visible. What sustains it is not.

Great Leap Sideways



Sana Khan

Systems of exchange used to be held together by obligation, and later by markets. The present moment, however, sits somewhere in between, it is unstable and unfinished.

Exchange has not disappeared.]

It has multiplied.

But the structures that once made it hold have weakened.

Earlier, reciprocity depended on continuity. To give was part of an ongoing relation, one that carried memory, expectation, and consequence. Return was naturally enforced at every moment because it was already built into the relationship itself. Refusing to do so was not neutral, it had weight.

That weight seems to disappear for some reason now.

Exchange persists without the durability that once governed it. What was earlier carried through expectation is now resolved through transaction. Payment closes this interaction. It's used as a substitution now. When things like care becomes purchasable, they also becomes transferable. When it becomes transferable, it becomes replaceable. And once it becomes replaceable, the relationship erodes.

The shift is subtle, but it accumulates.

Substitution weakens pressure. So if one relationship fails, another can take its place. Transaction compensates where obligation falls short.

Interactions remain frequent, but increasingly self-contained. Each exchange resolves itself. Each interaction closes. Continuity is no longer assumed, it has to be actively maintained, and it is not anymore.

This does not appear immediately as breakdown.

It erodes quietly through repetition. Obligations become negotiable, then optional, and eventually indistinguishable from preference. Things which used to sustain themselves through expectations then become dependent on individual willingness alone and this willingness is unstable.

In such a setting, imbalance produces adjustment instead of outright rupture. One side absorbs more, compensates more. The system continues, but without correcting itself.

This is why it does not collapse. It stretches.

Should they take too much, there would be nothing left to give.



Homo Reciprocans